Academic freedom for librarians and archivists

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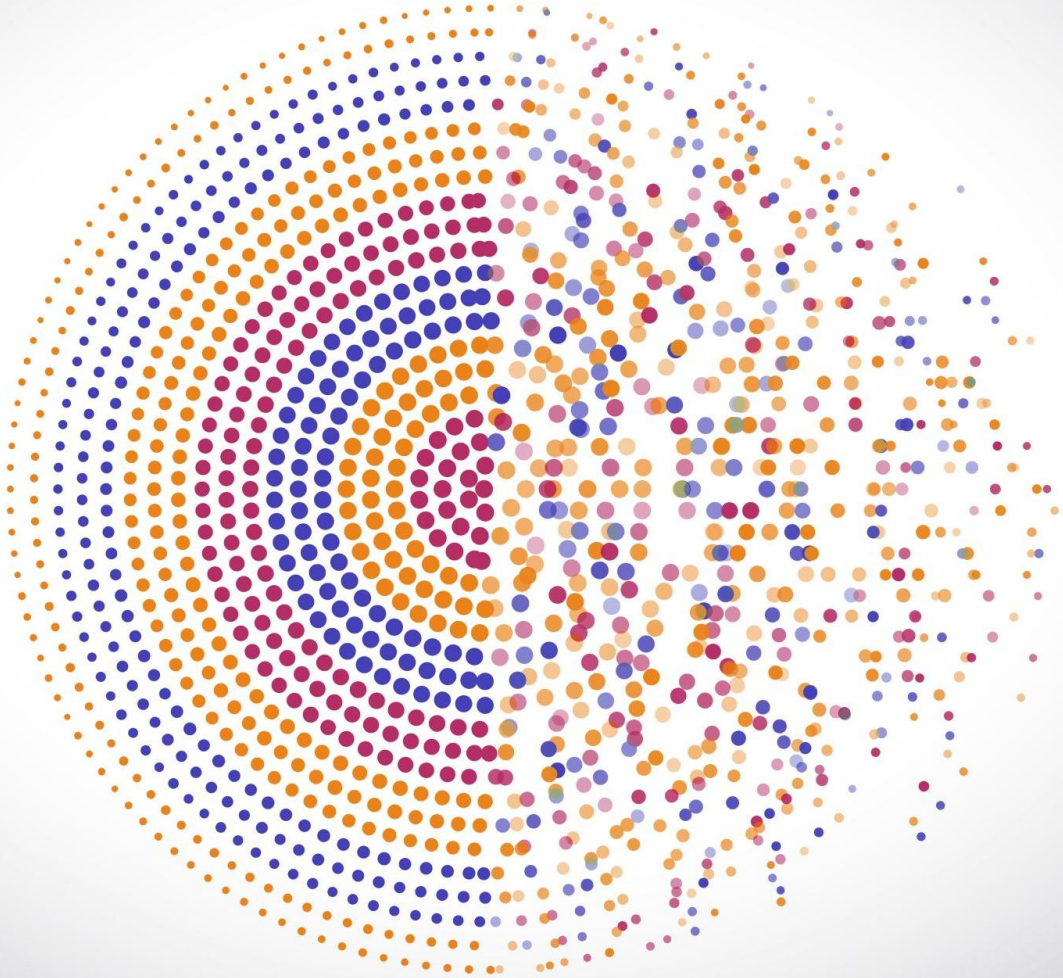
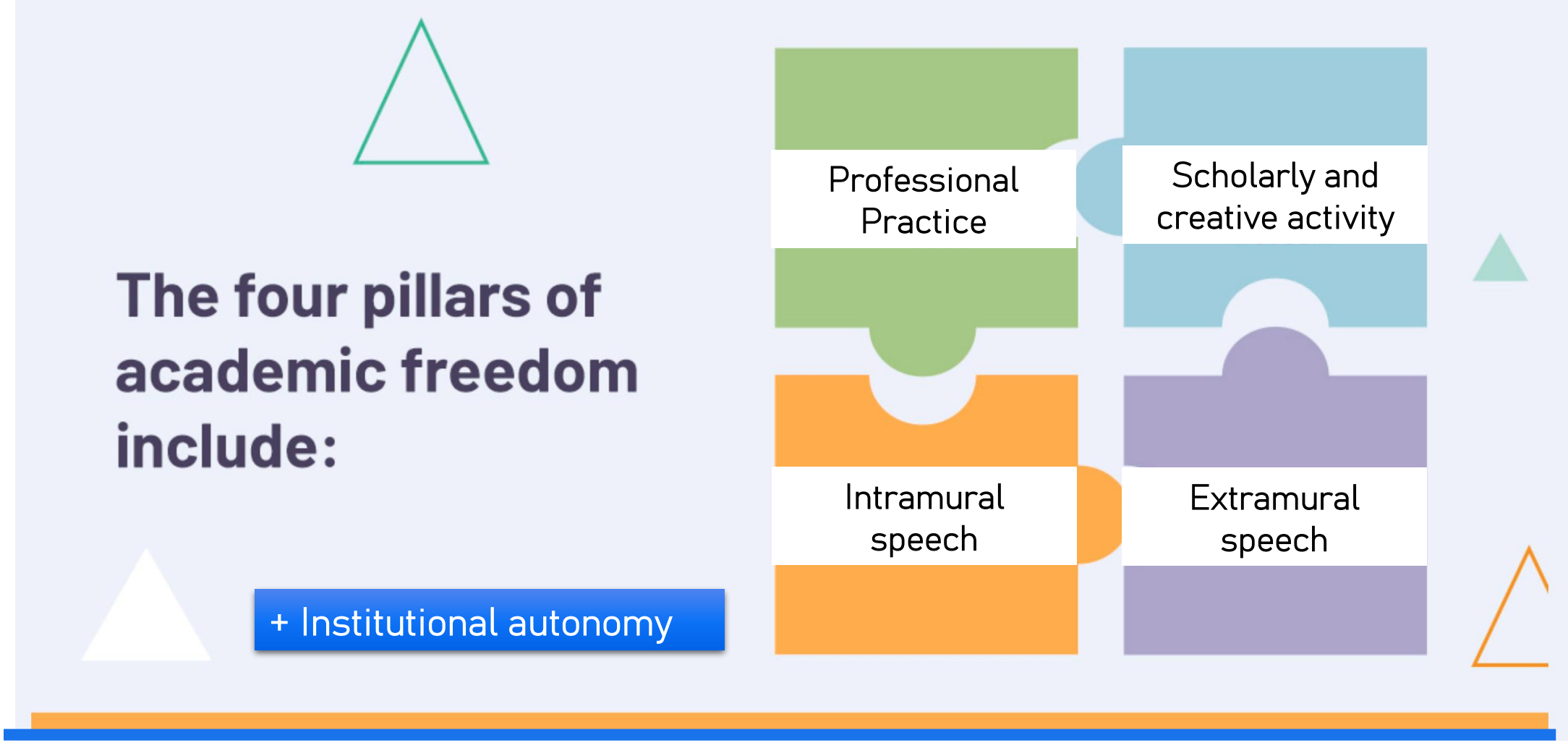


My everyday definition of academic freedom:

Academic freedom is the freedom to do all components of my job in ways I think they should be done without any interference from my employer or others. I can – and do – refuse work based on academic freedom. I also use academic freedom in my decisions regarding service and scholarship.

Academic freedom also includes expressive rights: my right to critique or comment on my employer, how work is organized, library policies and so on.

How have you operationalized academic freedom? Is your day-to-day academic freedom different than mine?



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Professional practice: Challenges

- Individual autonomy vs working in teams
- Time constraints and overemphasis on professional practice at the expense of scholarly/creative work and service.
- Critique can be misunderstood as an attack on the team.
- Recent re-orgs in academic libraries tend to emphasize more team-based approaches than individual autonomy.
- Hierarchical nature of library / archival workplace.

Collegiality ≠ Congeniality

Collegiality is the full participation of academic staff in the institutional processes that shape the conditions of academic work. Alongside fair employment practices, equity and inclusion in the workplace, academic freedom, and others, collegiality is a fundamental condition of academic work necessary for the ongoing fulfilment of the academic mission.

To be clear, collegiality is not about the comportment of individuals and must not be confused with congeniality or civility.

CAUT, "A Brief Introduction to Collegial Governance."

Library “nice”

- Library nice encourages and rewards self-policing in workplaces regulated by concepts of politeness and "respect".
- Library nice is defined as “a heavily gendered and racialized form of workplace oppression in which some people—white women and people of color—must always conform to rigid expectations of ‘niceness,’ and whether a librarian is ‘nice’ is more important than their knowledge, skill, or effectiveness." (From the article called *Leaving the Low-Morale Experience: A Qualitative Study*.)
- CARL's "Core competencies for 21st century librarians" : interpersonal skills are highly valued, and the long list of desirable traits includes adaptability, eagerness, flexibility, open-mindedness, conflict-resolution skills, collaboration, the capacity to "seek and nurture meaningful relationships and partnerships," be an active listener, be open to feedback, and so on.

Scholarly and creative activities: Challenges

Kandiuk & Sonne de Torrens (2018) / Harrington & Gerolami (2014) key points:

- Academic freedom protections often exist for Canadian academic librarians vis à vis scholarly and creative works, but unevenly.
- Definitions of scholarly activities differ: some must conform to narrowly defined LIS or archival topics, others are obligated to obtain the approval of the University Librarian, while some have autonomy in choosing research topics.
- Research is expected but not always supported. Eight-one percent of Canadian academic librarians have scholarly activities in their workloads, but they are not meaningfully integrated into day-to-day responsibilities. Time constraints and heavy service/administrative duties are major obstacles.
- As more librarians obtain advanced degrees, the tension between scholarly identities and obligations vs professional expectations and constraints is heightened.
- Our scholarly work requires *academic freedom and the time and resources* to pursue meaningful scholarly and creative works.

The ‘Duty of loyalty’ and intra/extramural speech

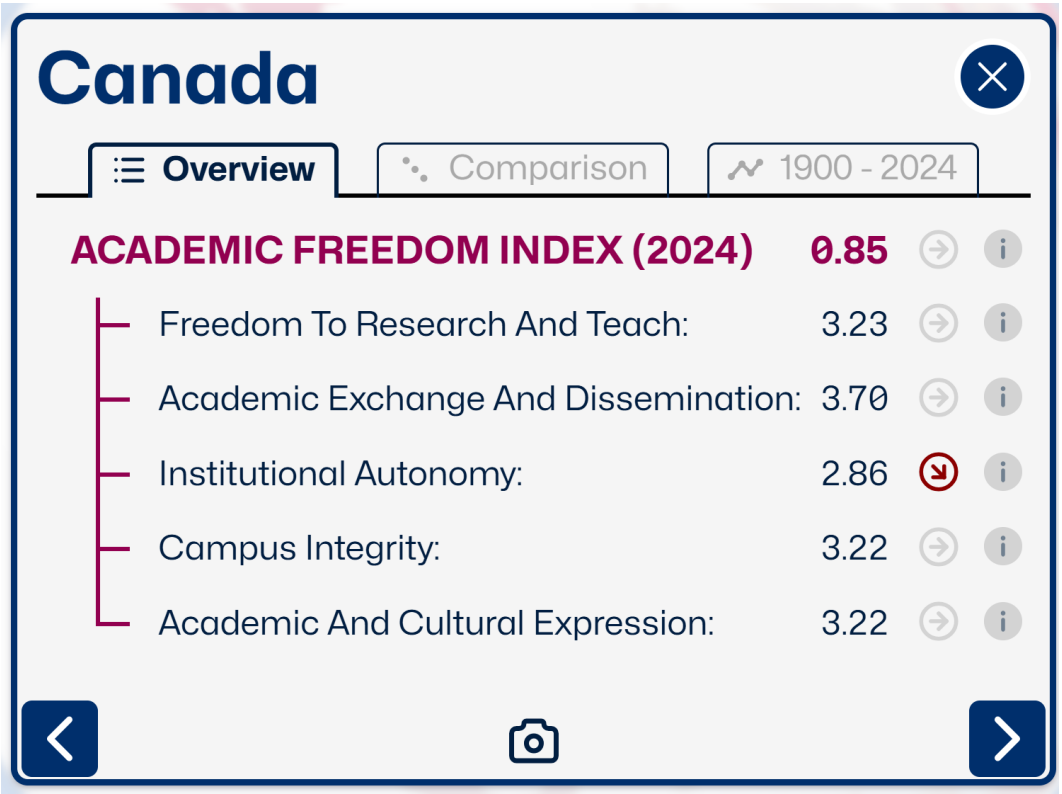
“The duty of loyalty – and particularly the obligation not to criticize one’s employer or to damage the employer’s reputation – has no place in academic workplaces.” (Robinson, “No Place for “duty of loyalty” in Academia,” *CAUT Bulletin*, October 2022.)

Concerns about “civility” can too easily be used as justification for limiting contentious and divisive teaching, research, and expression. But argument and debate, often pointed and controversial, lie at the heart of the academic mission. (CAUT, “The Limits and Non-Limits of Academic Freedom” n.d.).

Institutional autonomy

- Institutional autonomy is important for upholding academic freedom. It allows universities to set policies without external influence, for example by governments and private industry.
- **Alberta:** passed **Bill 18 The Provincial Priorities Act** requiring universities to obtain provincial approval before accepting federal funding.
- **Nova Scotia**: **Bill 12** allows the minister to withhold funding if a university does not align with government-imposed social and economic priorities and allows the minister to appoint up to half of a university's Board of Governors, thereby granting the government direct influence over university governance.
- **Ontario:** passed **Bill 33** "Supporting Children and Students Act" so the government can regulate and override student fees, weakening student unions; It also requires universities to use "merit-based" criteria for admissions limiting who has access to PSE.
- Reduced funding / tying funding to "priority" areas is a common tactic that weakens institutional autonomy and has cascading effects on academic freedom.

The downward slide of academic freedom in Canada



Source: Academic Freedom Index, 2025.

Canada has dropped nearly 1 point since 2019 due to the decline in institutional autonomy and policies like the STRAC (Policy on Sensitive Technology Research and Affiliations of Concern) which targets researchers from specific countries – mostly China, but also Russia and Iran.

What conditions are conducive to academic freedom?

Respect for International law, human rights, academic freedom and Charter rights

- The right to freedom of assembly and association.
- Freedom of thought, belief, opinion and expression.
- The right to information, sources of information, and the tools, materials, and methods necessary to gather, develop, interpret, and share information and ideas Any limitations must be consistent with international law and not arbitrary ideas (Shaheed, *Academic Freedom*, 2024).

Local and individual conditions

- Institutional and individual autonomy. This refers to both independence of thought and action as well as immunity from undue influence.
- Job security: Tenure is vital to ensuring that academic staff remain autonomous without fear of reprisal.
- Effective complaints or grievance procedures.
- Support from the employer and the union. This may involve support for psychological safety and also legal support in the face of complaints against librarians or faculty members, etc.
- Safety and financial security. People of colour and those with less financial security feel less safe using expressive rights (Leebaw and Logsdon, "The Cost of Speaking Out," 2019).

Documented AF cases of Librarians and Archivists

- Dale Askey / Edwin Mellen Press, ca. 2010.
- Librarian terminated without just cause at Saint Paul University in 2013. She was the Vice-President of the union. The librarian settled the grievance instead of going to arbitration.
- University of Regina librarian whose service was to the Flying Pickets, 2024.

Do you self-censor in your research or service activities, suspecting your employer will not support them?

Do you ask for permission to engage in certain types of research, professional, or service activities to prevent rebuke from administrators or supervisors?

Academic freedom infringements where no grievance or complaint was filed

- Censorship of a display of Palestinian works in an Ontario college library in 2024 (mentioned during a presentation of Librarians and Archivists for Palestine in December 2024).
- Administration removed a pro-LGBTQ+ poster from a librarian's office door (uOttawa) in 2022.
- Kandiuk and Sonne de Torrens (2018) found that > 60% percent of librarian respondents to a survey indicated that prior approval was "sometimes" required for research agendas.

What prevents archivists and librarians from enforcing academic freedom rights?

WORKPLACE CULTURE

- Oppressive library "nice" culture, especially for people of colour and white women (Kaetrena Davis Kendrick, "Leaving the Low-Morale Experience: A Qualitative Study," 2021).
- Conflating collegiality and congeniality (Shin Freedman, "Collegiality Matters: How Do We Work With Others?" 2009).
- Team-based work environments (untested hypothesis, but also hypothesized in Bordonaro, "Too Much of a Good Thing?" 2025).
- Workplace power relations & fear of retaliation (Vaisey, "The Quiet Librarian: Workplace Complaints and Collegiality," 2014).
- Having other outlets for complaints (Ming and Matteson, "The Airing of Grievances," 2023).
- Believing that the union won't be effective or supportive, being unsure of their rights (Vaisey, "The Quiet Librarian: Workplace Complaints and Collegiality," 2014).
- L & A on short term contracts (CAUT, "Take Action – Academic Freedom and Equity," 2024).

PROFESSIONAL CHARACTERISTICS

- Gratitude for the freedom and autonomy in our jobs (CAUT Librarians and Archivists interviews, 2024-2025).
- Self-policing, self-censorship.

COLLECTIVE AGREEMENTS

- Need for permission / release time for research and service (Harrington and Gerolami, "Highs and Lows," 2014).
- CA language that assigns responsibility for intellectual freedom to librarians, causing confusion between intellectual freedom and academic freedom, and making l & a responsible for the intellectual freedom of others on campus.
- Limitations on research (e.g. related to one's position, furthering library goals, or "cannot be detrimental" to professional activities) (Harrington and Gerolami, "Highs and Lows," 2014; Kandiuk and Sonne de Torrens, "Academic Freedom and Librarians' Research and Scholarship in Canadian Universities," 2018).

Building stronger cultures of academic freedom

- Create awareness and venues for discussion.
- Mentor new colleagues. Role-model what academic freedom looks like.
- Minimize dependence on contract librarians and archivists.
- Make sure archivists are in the faculty association and have academic freedom too.
- Work on psychological safety so that people feel safe exercising academic freedom.
- Get familiar with CAUT. Read the Academic Freedom Toolkit. Know that our unions and CAUT have our backs.
- File complaints and grievances when necessary. Ask colleagues to sign on to group grievances.
- Improve the collective agreement if there are limitations on academic freedom for librarians with respect to research, service, or if there are requirements to uphold others' intellectual freedoms.
- Be aware that not all colleagues have the same experience of the workplace: people of colour and disabled colleagues are more at risk of harassment when speaking out. People who are financially precarious may not be able to exercise academic freedom until they have job security and better pay. Example: Of 117 faculty members who contacted Palestine Legal and identified their race in 2025, 84% were people of color. (Pratt, "Professor sues Texas university that terminated contract after Palestine talk,"*Guardian News* March 24, 2026).

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